

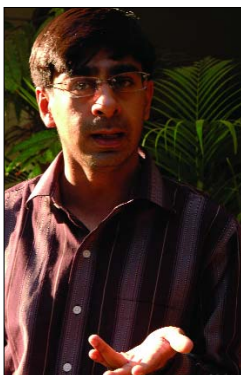
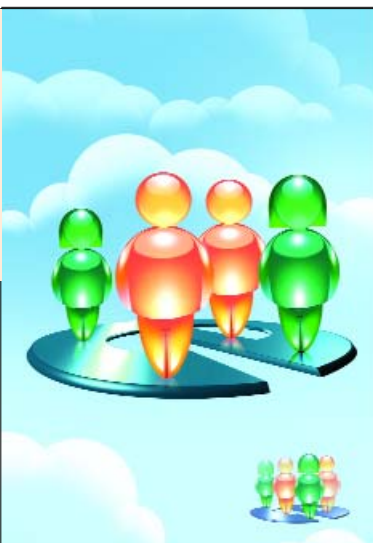


**Ravi Vaidyanathan**  
Officer (Operations & MIS),  
ILFS, Mumbai

I became a member of the Friendster.com a year ago. Courtesy: a friend of mine who is quite active in this network. It's been useful to keep in touch with friends, who have shifted out of Mumbai and are part of the network. E-mails do zip through and fro keeping us updated about the whereabouts of everyone in the group. Other than that, I have also got in touch with people who have turned out to be potential business contacts.

I log onto the network every two or three days. Yes, I do make a lot of contacts. I started with three and then went on to build a network of 50 people. They in turn have contacts themselves and thus I get introduced to many more. Friendster does encourage me to share information and exchange ideas and opinions about a particular topic that the group discusses online. Also, I get to know about diverse cultures and meet people from different societies and strata. A cool way of keeping with the times!

# BUSINESS

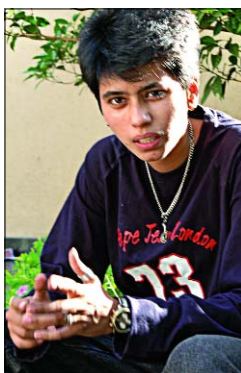


**Nikhil Handa**  
Assistant Manager,  
Nicholas Piramal India Ltd

Friendster.com is a wonderful way of networking with people. I was introduced to this novel concept about six months back. You put up your profile, browse through other profiles and invite people whom you think share the same thoughts and interests. I do browse through the site once in a week and come in contact with quite a number of like-minded people, some of whom are mature professionals.

Business-wise, yes, it has been helpful. Here's how: my work involves clinical research, which entails that the company provide insurance to patients being treated. While looking out for potential insurance providers, I came across an individual who did provide the same. We met, discussed the deal and have been doing business ever since.

Apart from that, it has helped me share and exchange opinions with other Friendster friends. I feel sites such as Friendster let you expand your horizon and increase your knowledge as well.



**Chitra Marathe**  
Guitarist, Mumbai

Orkut, Google.com's take on online networking saw me becoming its member three months ago. I had no idea that such an idea was in place on the Web until my friend sent me an invitation. Since then, I have been an active member within the community. It was here that I got to meet people, who shared my fascination for music.

I networked with them, and have gained a lot through our exchange of ideas. I log on to the Web site everyday to check for new messages, etc. I don't add people at random. I restrict myself to those with whom I have had a proper correspondence. Till date I have 46 friends in Orkut. Offline meetings do happen but given my hectic schedule I have been able to attend just a few of them.

Orkut is a great pastime and has helped me adapt to attitudes which I would not have otherwise. It was through Orkut that I got to know about a drama production company called the Open Theatre group. I got through its auditions and am now looking forward to its upcoming venture.

*As told to Garfield D'Souza*